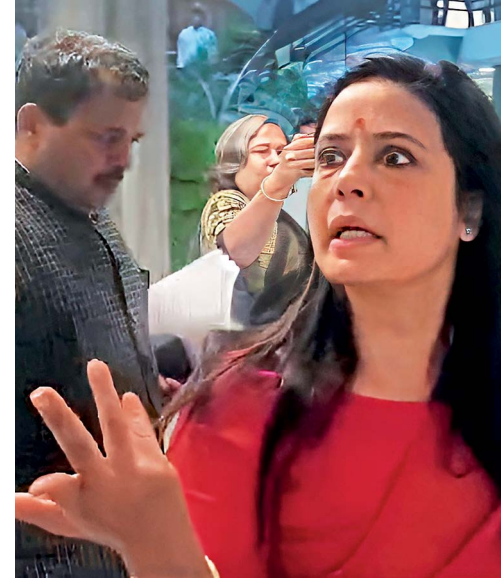






Photographs by ANI

the BJP," the West Bengal chief minister told journalists after news came about the expulsion.

Mahua might feel a bit aggrieved, that she has been done in by the "circumstances". Even before the cash-for-query controversy erupted, brought to light by her long-time nemesis, BJP MP Nishikant Dubey, there had been much discussion on social media about the firebrand MP's chic sense of fashion and branded accessories, not all of it in a positive light. The knives had been out for long, ever since her first speech in Parliament in 2019 touched on the "seven signs of early fascism in India".

Since then it's been all fire and brimstone with Mahua losing no opportunity to haul the Modi government over the coals over its sins of omission and commission. So much so, many a time it seemed like she was playing a lone hand from the Opposition benches.

Playing so far out in enemy territory, it was expected that she would catch some buckshot at some point. But it was friendly fire from unexpected corners—a "jilted ex" and then a "close personal friend"—that finally did her in. First, former consort Jai Anant Dehadrai, a 35-year-old Supreme Court lawyer, sent off a 39-page letter with a litany of allegations against Mahua to the CBI and Dubey. But the allegations needed corroboration. Dubai-based real estate magnate Darshan Hiranandani, who was accused in the letter of giving luxury gifts/ cash to Mahua for asking questions in the Lok Sabha against the Gautam Adani conglomerate, provided that in the form of an affidavit. Armed with these allegations, a 495-page Lok Sabha ethics panel report indicted Mahua, finally leading to her expulsion from the House.

Saying she still has "30-plus years of political life left in her", Mahua is sure she'll win in the general election under Mamata*di*'s leadership

The former Wall Street investment banker may be out, but she is not done, not yet anyway. "Of course I am contesting [the next general election]. And, yes, I am winning," Mahua told INDIA TODAY on being asked if she would enter the electoral fray again. "I have 30-plus years of political life left in me. Under Mamata*di*'s leadership, I will spend every waking moment fighting this fascist Modi government and its corrupt crony Adani nexus.... Nothing, but nothing, will get me down." Brave words to live by. ■